

C2: Social Media - definitions and general aspects



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Socialisation

- The process by which we learn to become members of society - by internalising society's norms and values and learning social roles.
- Permanent adaptation
- Integration of the individual into social structures
- Is achieved and developed through interaction

Sociality ? Sociability

- For some authors, they can have the same meaning, being interchangeable
 - Sociality =RO dictionary: the character of what is social; Cambridge Dictionary: the fact of living together in an organized way as a society
- The way people associate with each other to form social relationships and societies Miller et al. 2016
- Sociality - the constitutive premise of society
 - Sociability = the ability to interact with others, to integrate into society
 - Simmel: sociability includes only positive manifestations of sociality (i.e. altruism, cooperation, gregariousness, mutual aid, etc.
 - Cambridge Dictionary: the quality of liking to meet and spend time with other people

Sociability

Sociable individual: shows a willingness to establish and maintain social relationships with peers.

Sociability: the permanent ability of people to live in a group - mutual obligation

"Man is by nature a social animal." (Aristotle in ***Politics***)

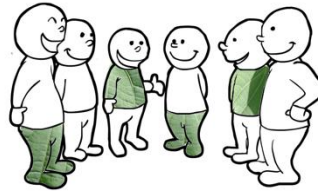
"Remove sociability, and you destroy the union of the human race" (Seneca in ***On Benefactions***)

Sociability: the totality of an individual's personal relationships, taking into account their form;
It refers to the network that supports it: = gr. ***philia*** (the bond that maintains unity between members of a group)

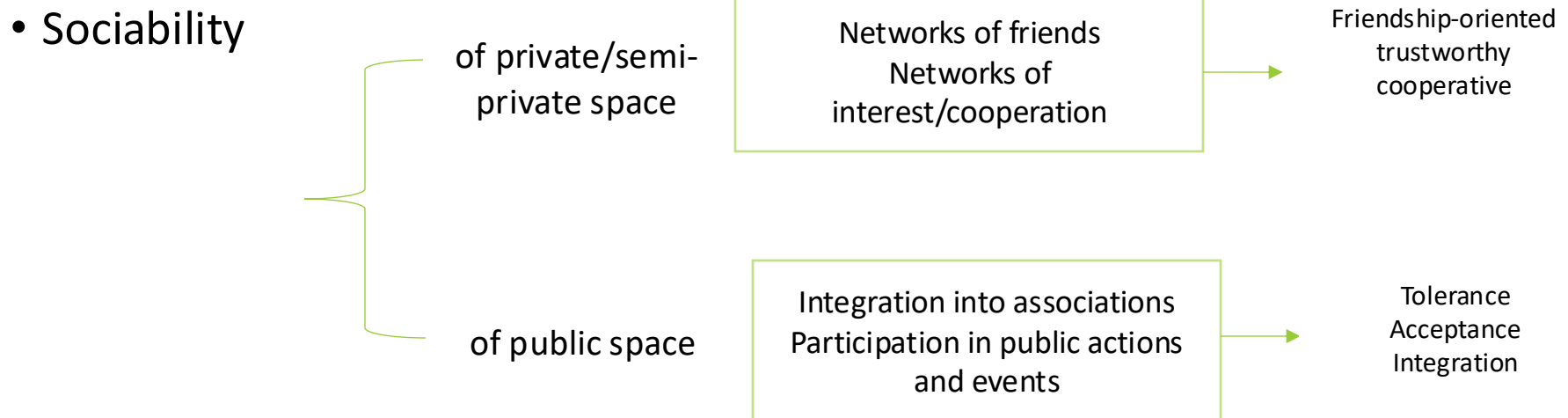
"it is the game in the course of which we <<do>> as if all were equal" (Simmel, 1917) - the playful form of socialisation (through which social units are formed)

Sociability

- "Sociability is ... a positive type of relationship with actual or potential benefits for all actors involved". (Sandu, 2003, p.15)



- Sociability is **relational** and based on phenomena of association, social bonding



<https://youtu.be/0jA5B32MP98?si=jOvEgy9zSIOn5cf9>



More about the project on: <https://www.ucl.ac.uk/why-we-post>

[SCALABLE SOCIALITY]

HOW SOCIAL MEDIA HAS CREATED A NEW POTENTIAL FOR SOCIALITY



TWO KEY SCALES OF SOCIALITY :
From the most private to the most public
From the smallest group to the largest group

The background of the slide is a dark, abstract composition. It features a dense pattern of small, out-of-focus light circles in shades of teal, orange, and white, creating a bokeh effect. Overlaid on this is a grid of small, semi-transparent dots in the same color palette, which appears to recede into the distance, giving a sense of depth and digital connectivity.

How do we define Social Media? Interdisciplinary perspectives



Social media is the colonization of the space between traditional broadcast and private dyadic communication, providing people with a scale of group size and degrees of privacy that we have termed “scalable sociality.” (Miller et al., 2016, p.19)



Evolution of Social Media Definitions and Applications

Early Usage:

- The term "social media" first appeared in 1994 on Tokyo's online platform, Matisse.

Growth Over Time:

- Significant increase in both the number of platforms and active users.

Key Applications:

- **Communication:** Facilitating user interactions.
- **Content Sharing:** Enabling distribution of user-generated content.
- **Collaboration:** Supporting cooperative projects and discussions.

Aichner, T., Grünfelder, M., Maurer, O., & Jegeni, D. (2021). Twenty-Five Years of Social Media: A Review of Social Media Applications and Definitions from 1994 to 2019. *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking*, 24(4), 215-222.

DEFINITIONS

Extensive but simplistic:

- “those that facilitate online communication, networking, and/or collaboration” (Russo, Watkins, Kelly & Chan, 2008 p. 22).
- “a group of Internet-based applications that build on the ideological and technological foundations of Web 2.0, and that allow the creation and exchange of User Generated Content” (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2010, p. 61)
- Social media” simply serve as a “label for digital technologies that allow people to connect, interact, produce and share content” (Lewis, 2010, p. 2).
- Social networking sites typically provide users with a profile space, facilities for uploading content (e.g., photos, music), messaging in various forms, and the ability to make connections to other people. (Joinson, 2008)

General:

- “(a) the information infrastructure and tools used to produce and distribute content; (b) the content that takes the digital form of personal messages, news, ideas, and cultural products; and (c) the people, organizations, and industries that produce and consume digital content.” (Howards & Parks, 2012, p. 362)

...

- „Social media is the latest buzzword in a long line of buzzwords. It is often used to describe the collection of software that enables individuals and communities to gather, communicate, share, and in some cases collaborate or play. In tech circles, social media has replaced the earlier fave ‘social software’. Academics still tend to prefer terms like ‘computer-mediated communication’ or ‘computer-supported co-operative work’ to describe the practices that emerge from these tools and the old skool academics might even categorize these tools as ‘groupwork’ tools. Social media is driven by another buzzword: ‘user-generated content’ or content that is contributed by participants rather than editors” (boyd, 2009).
- „Social media indicate a shift from HTML-based linking practices of the open web to liking and recommendation, which happen inside closed systems. Web 2.0 has three distinguishing features: it is easy to use, it facilitates sociality, and it provides users with free publishing and production platforms that allow them to upload content in any form, be it pictures, videos, or text” (Lovink, 2011, p.5).
- “... programmers these days loosely glue everything together with code. Connect persons to data objects to persons. That’s the social today” (Lovink, 2012, p.11).



...

- Since at least 2004, the internet, and more specifically the web, has witnessed a notorious and controversial shift away from the model of the static web page towards a social web or Web 2.0 model where the possibilities of users to interact with the web have multiplied. It has become much easier for a layperson to publish and share texts, images and sounds. A new topology of distribution of information has emerged, based in 'real' social networks, but also enhanced by casual and algorithmic connections" (Terranova & Donovan, 2013, p. 297).

- Social media are Internet-based channels that allow users to opportunistically interact and selectively self-present, either in real-time or asynchronously, with both broad and narrow audiences who derive value from user-generated content and the perception of interaction with others. (Carr& Hayes, 2015, p. 50)

<i>Social Medium</i>	<i>Not a Social Medium</i>
• Social network sites (e.g., Facebook, QQ, Google+, YouTube, Yelp, Pheed) • Professional network sites (e.g., LinkedIn, IBM's Beehive) • Chatboards & discussion fora • Social/Casual games (e.g., Farmville) • Wiki "Talk" pages • Tinder • Instagram • Wanelo • Yik Yak	• Online news services (e.g., <i>NYT</i> online, PerezHilton.com) • Wikipedia • Skype • Netflix • E-mail • Online news • SMS/Texts • Oovoo • Tumblr • Whisper

Table 1: Adaptation of contemporary examples based on the above definition, according to Carr and Hayes, 2015, p.52

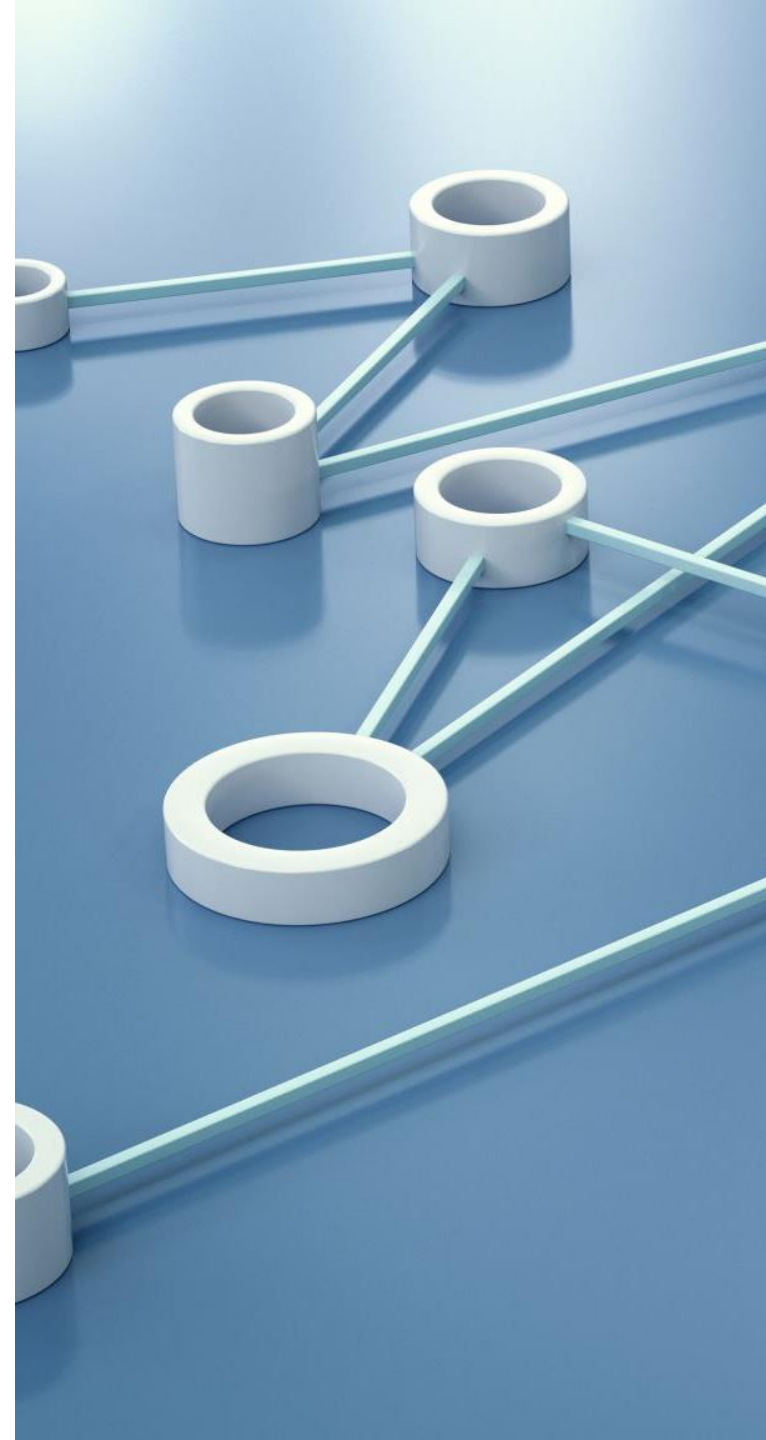
Social media is media that is designed for and centered around social interaction. It is commonly associated with a conglomeration of web-based technologies and services such as blogs, wikis, media-sharing services, collaborative editing tools, and social networking services that enable and empower users to communicate, interact, edit, and share content in a social environment (Bertot, Jaeger, & Grimes, 2012, p. 82).



Social network sites are web-based services that allow individuals to

- (a) construct a public or semi-public profile within a bounded system,
- (b) articulate a list of other users with whom they share a connection, and
- (c) view and traverse their list of connections and those made by others within the system.

(boyd & Ellison, 2007, p.211).





A social network site is a networked communication platform in which participants (a) have uniquely identifiable profiles that consist of user-supplied content, content provided by other users, and/or system-level data; (b) can publicly articulate connections that can be viewed and traversed by others; and (c) can consume, produce, and/or interact with streams of user-generated content provided by their connections on the site. (Ellison & boyd, 2013, p. 152)

Social Networking Sites versus Social Media

Castells (2009): SNS allow a form of mass communication of the self through which individuals can learn a new creative autonomy.

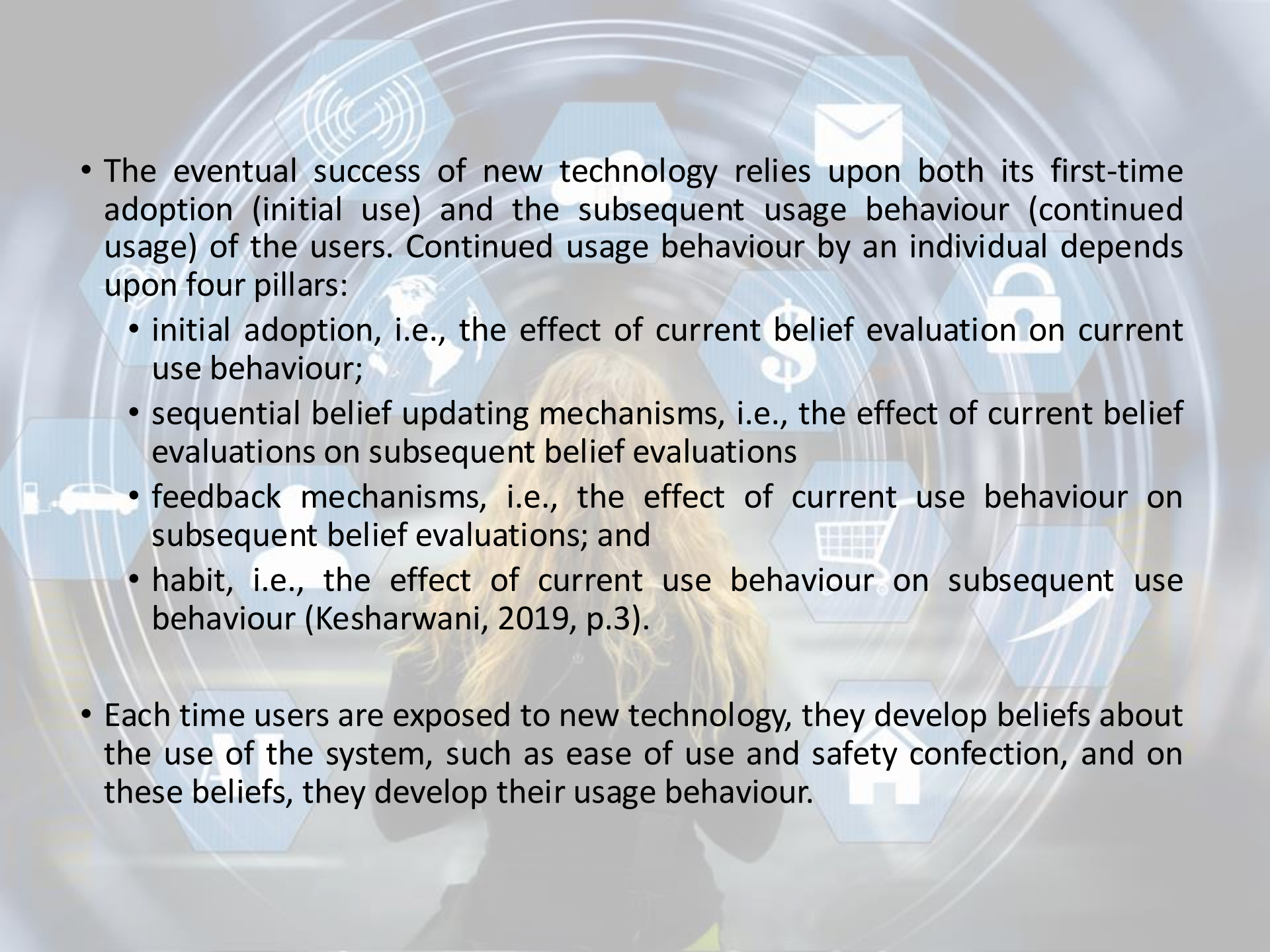
Stiegler (2009): process of individualisation and public expression - factor of emancipation/empowerment and opposition/resistance.

SNS	SM
Interaction --> communication	Interaction --> diffusion (spreading content)
Interpersonal communication<->	„Medium is the message” McLuhan Media platforms
Public platforms based on individuals interconnected by common interests/purposes	Spread, share and brake information Wide audience

Most often they overlap



- + Quick interaction, we choose who we interact with, we receive information, keep in touch with acquaintances, personal promotion, share content
- No anonymity, harassment, pranks, manipulation, time-consuming

- 
- The background of the slide features a faint, circular pattern of concentric lines. Overlaid on this are several blue hexagonal icons containing white symbols: a Wi-Fi signal, an envelope, a padlock, a shopping cart, a house, a car, a person, and a dollar sign. In the center, there is a silhouette of a woman with long, wavy blonde hair, looking down.
- The eventual success of new technology relies upon both its first-time adoption (initial use) and the subsequent usage behaviour (continued usage) of the users. Continued usage behaviour by an individual depends upon four pillars:
 - initial adoption, i.e., the effect of current belief evaluation on current use behaviour;
 - sequential belief updating mechanisms, i.e., the effect of current belief evaluations on subsequent belief evaluations
 - feedback mechanisms, i.e., the effect of current use behaviour on subsequent belief evaluations; and
 - habit, i.e., the effect of current use behaviour on subsequent use behaviour (Kesharwani, 2019, p.3).
 - Each time users are exposed to new technology, they develop beliefs about the use of the system, such as ease of use and safety confection, and on these beliefs, they develop their usage behaviour.

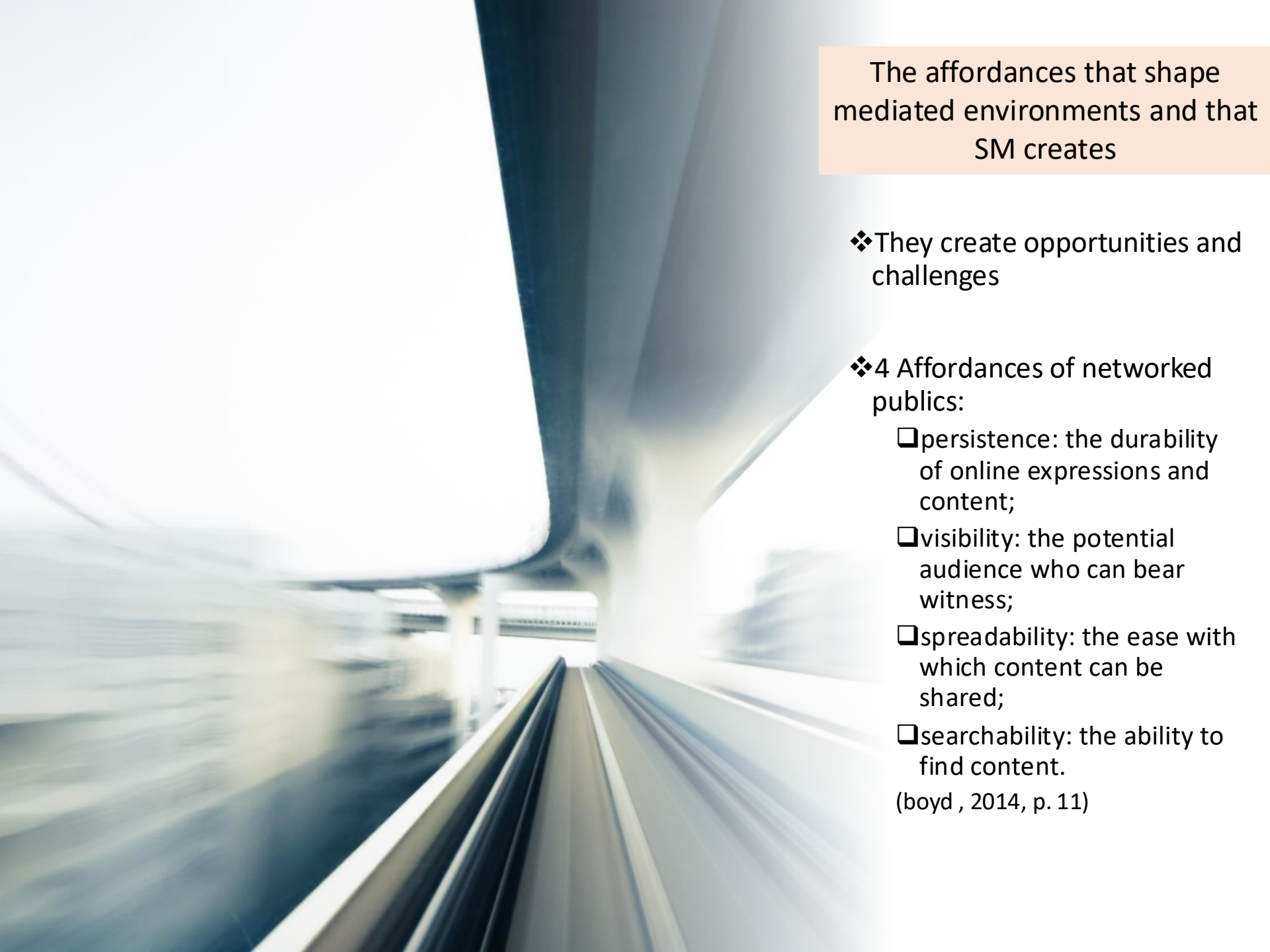


Understanding Social Media Affordances

- Social media affordances are the perceived actual or imagined properties of social media, emerging through the relation of technological, social, and contextual, that enable and constrain specific uses of the platform

Affordances in Social Media:

- Features that enable specific user interactions and behaviors.
- Ronzhyn, Cardenal, and Batlle Rubio (2022): examples of affordances include
 - **Visibility**
 - **Editability**
 - **Persistence:**
 - **Association:**



The affordances that shape mediated environments and that SM creates

❖ They create opportunities and challenges

❖ 4 Affordances of networked publics:

- ❑ persistence: the durability of online expressions and content;
- ❑ visibility: the potential audience who can bear witness;
- ❑ spreadability: the ease with which content can be shared;
- ❑ searchability: the ability to find content.

(boyd , 2014, p. 11)

Key elements

- ❑ *User-generated content*
- ❑ *User-generated interaction* [different kinds of interaction]
- ❑ Message Directionality/ Two-way communication()
- ❑ Audience [selective]
- ❑ Specific infrastructure and tools used in the production and delivery of messages
- ❑ Web 2.0
- ❑ *Social Networks/ Social Network Sites*

+ / -



Advantages:

- ✓ Quick interaction and global connectivity
- ✓ Personal branding and content sharing
- ✓ Access to information



Disadvantages:

- ✗ Privacy issues and online harassment
- ✗ Manipulation and misinformation
- ✗ Time-consuming distractions

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Mandatory readings :

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